

The Month-End Close Checklist

A repeatable close, in the order that actually works

WHO THIS IS FOR

Bookkeepers and owners who want figures they can trust before the 10th.

WHAT IS INSIDE

- The close in seven ordered stages
- The reconciliations that catch the most errors
- A short review checklist before you sign it off
- A simple close timetable you can hand to staff

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Why order matters

A close done out of order produces numbers that move after you have looked at them. Cash first, then what you are owed, then what you owe, then the adjustments. Each stage depends on the one before it.

Stage 1 — Cash

- ☐ Every bank account reconciled to the statement, to the cent
- ☐ Credit card and loan accounts reconciled
- ☐ Card machine and payment gateway settlements matched to deposits
- ☐ Petty cash counted and agreed
- ☐ Unpresented items reviewed — anything older than three months investigated
- ☐ Suspense account cleared to zero

Stage 2 — What you are owed

- ☐ All sales invoices for the month raised and sent
- ☐ Debtors age analysis agreed to the debtors control account
- ☐ Credit notes processed in the correct month
- ☐ Deposits and payments in advance treated as liabilities, not income
- ☐ Anything over 90 days flagged for a decision, not just noted again

Stage 3 — What you owe

- ☐ All supplier invoices captured, including those still sitting in an inbox
- ☐ Creditors age analysis agreed to the creditors control account
- ☐ Supplier statements reconciled for your major accounts
- ☐ Accruals raised for costs incurred but not yet invoiced to you
- ☐ Prepayments split so the cost falls in the right months

Stage 4 — Payroll and people

- ☐ Payroll journal posted and agreed to the payroll reports
- ☐ Net pay per the payroll agreed to what actually left the bank
- ☐ PAYE, UIF and SDL liabilities agreed to the EMP201
- ☐ Leave and bonus provisions updated
- ☐ Any loans to or from staff reviewed

Stage 5 — VAT

- ☐ VAT control account reconciled to the VAT return for the period
- ☐ Zero-rated and exempt supplies checked for correct treatment
- ☐ Input VAT claimed only where a valid tax invoice is held
- ☐ Entertainment, motor cars and other blocked inputs excluded
- ☐ Prior period corrections tracked separately, not buried

A VAT control account that never quite balances is the single most common sign that a set of books needs attention.

Stage 6 — Adjustments and assets

- ☐ Depreciation posted for the month
- ☐ New assets added to the fixed asset register, not expensed by accident
- ☐ Assets disposed of or scrapped removed, with the profit or loss recognised
- ☐ Stock count or movement processed, and cost of sales checked against gross margin
- ☐ Loan accounts and interest agreed to statements
- ☐ Owner's drawings and personal expenses posted where they belong

Stage 7 — Review before you call it closed

Print the income statement and balance sheet and ask these five questions. If any answer is a shrug, the close is not finished.

- Does the gross margin look like last month? If not, do I know why?
- Is every balance sheet line supported by something I could show a third party?
- Are there any negative balances that make no sense — negative stock, negative creditors?
- Did anything unusually large hit a single expense account this month?
- Would I be comfortable if this month's figures were the ones a bank looked at?

A close timetable that works

WORKING DAY	WHAT HAPPENS
Day 1 to 2	Capture outstanding supplier invoices; raise all sales invoices
Day 3	Bank, card and cash reconciliations
Day 4	Debtors and creditors reconciliations; supplier statements

WORKING DAY	WHAT HAPPENS
Day 5	Payroll journal, accruals, prepayments, depreciation
Day 6	VAT reconciliation and review questions
Day 7	Management accounts issued, with a short commentary

Would you rather not do this yourself?

We have kept books, filed returns and run payrolls from Amanzimtoti since 1980. Twenty minutes on the phone costs nothing and usually saves something.

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This document is general information about South African accounting and tax practice. It is not advice for your particular circumstances, and rules change — usually with the annual Budget. Confirm anything you intend to rely on.